

Love



A father pulls a child in and will not let the embrace be polite. Faces close, arms locked. This is love with a body.

Before you gather

- Read Day 2, Love, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Who did one kind thing for you this month that you did not earn?

Leader. Keep it concrete. If they stay vague, ask what the person actually did. Then open Hosea 11. God's love is action toward rebels, not a feeling. Do not start with whether they feel loved. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: God's love is not a mood, and it does not cancel His holiness. He gave His only Son to die for sinners.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Love is God choosing to give of Himself for our good. It is God's faithful commitment to rescue and restore. It is seen most clearly in God sending His Son, Jesus, to save sinners.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek agapē — to love, to delight in, to be well-pleased with.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 3:16

For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.

Together, open the flashcard for Love. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9

Stay in Hosea 11. Israel ran. God had loved them, taught them to walk, and still would not give them up. Ask what the text says before anyone describes how love feels. Do not reteach the journal. But God gave us these words.

When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son. The more they were called, the more they went away... Yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk; I took them up by their arms... I led them with cords of kindness, with the bands of love. How can I give you up, O Ephraim? My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender. I will not execute my burning anger... for I am God and not a man, the Holy One in your midst.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has the child done in this passage, and what does the Father refuse to do?

CORE

Leader. The more they were called, the more they went away. God will not give Ephraim up. His compassion grows warm. Love here is covenant action toward people who ran, not a compliment for people who behaved.

2. Verse 9 says, 'I am God and not a man,' right after God names His burning anger. How is His love different from ours when we are hurt?

Leader. People withdraw or pay back. God stays the Holy One and stays near. He will not execute His anger the way a man would. Do not say that means love cancels His anger. The verse still names burning anger. He is God.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 5:8 says God shows His love in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. How is that a different order from our relationships?

Leader. We love people who respond. He loved His enemies. Christ died for the ungodly. That order is the gospel. We did not become lovely and then get loved.

4. John 13:1 says Jesus loved His own to the end, in the hour they were about to fail Him. What does that love do? **CORE**

Leader. It stays, and it goes to a cross. He came to die. He was our substitute. This is not romance. It is the Son keeping covenant with people He knew would deny Him.

5. If the cross is the proof of God's love, where are we tempted to measure His love by how this month feels?

Leader. Suffering, silence, a hard week. Feelings are real. They are not the authority. The Spirit leads by the Word (John 16:13; John 17:17). Point them to Romans 5:8 and the blood. Do not rewrite love as God making life feel easy.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

God's love is God giving His Son to die for sinners who were not lovely.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Buy a meal for someone far from Jesus and sit down with them. If they ask why, say God's love is not a mood. He gave His Son to die for sinners who were not lovely.

Leader. Press for a name outside the church. See them, share a table, and talk about Jesus. A kindness that never names Christ is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for loving us while we were still sinners, and for giving Your Son.
2. Forgive us for loving people only when they are easy, and for treating Your love like a mood.
3. Send us this week with a meal and a true word about the cross.

Before you stumble

If someone says love means God is never angry, do not leave it. Say, 'Hosea 11 still names burning anger. Love does not cancel His holiness. The cross is where love and wrath meet in the substitute.' Wrath is week 7. You may say that in one sentence. Do not turn the hour into a therapy circle about who failed to love them.

WITH STUDENTS

Students hear love as approval. Ask, 'Does this Father approve of the running, or does He refuse to abandon the runner?' Those are not the same. Read verses 2 and 8. Let the text answer.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 John 4:9-10. In this is love: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation for our sins. Love has blood in it. Read it if you need a second witness.